

Japan



An island monarchy that has renounced its martial past to become the world's third-largest economy.

c.350 CE Japan is unified under the rule of the powerful Yamato clan.

538 CE Buddhism is introduced to Japan, through China and Korea.

604 CE Prince Shotoku issues the Constitution of 17 Articles, setting out ethical maxims of government, which shows Buddhist and Confucian influence.

645 Fujiwara Kamatari institutes a reformed system of government based upon the Chinese model of a complex, centralized administration.

670–714 The main temple in the Horyu-ji temple complex, the Golden Hall, is built by carpenters from Korea.

710 Heijoko (Nara) becomes the first permanent capital, modeled on the Chinese city of Chang'an.

794 The Heian period begins. The power of the emperors falls into hands of the Fujiwara clan. The capital moves to Heiankyo (modern Kyoto).

c.1020 Murashi Shikibu writes *The Tale of Genji*, thought to be the first-ever novel.

1150s–80s Civil war between rival clans results in the Fujiwara clan losing their grip on power.

1159 Following the battle known as the Heiji Disturbance, the Taira clan emerge as the most powerful family.

1185 A military government is consolidated under the leader of the Minamoto clan, Minamoto Yorimoto, after his defeat of the Taira clan.

1192 Minamoto Yorimoto forces the emperor to give him the title of shogun.

1274 The first Mongol invasion is defeated. The samurai resist the Yuan army, which is made up of Mongol, Chinese, and Korean soldiers.

Samurai fortress

Himeji Castle, begun in 1333, has all the defensive and architectural features of a Japanese medieval fortress, including gun emplacements and stone-dropping holes.

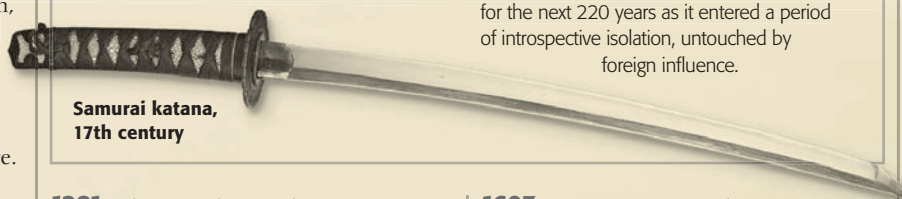
DECISIVE MOMENT

THE CLOSED COUNTRY EDICT, 1635

By the early 17th century, there were about half a million Christians in Japan, the largest number in any Asian country. Distrust of Europeans and fear of the subversive power of Christianity led the Tokugawa Shogunate to implement a series of anti-Christian and anti-foreigner measures, culminating in

1635 with the Closed Country Edict.

Addressed to two commissioners in the southern port Nagasaki, a stronghold of Christianity, the Edict forbade Japanese ships to leave for foreign countries, and ordered the execution by sword of anyone returning from abroad. The decision sealed the fate of Japan for the next 220 years as it entered a period of introspective isolation, untouched by foreign influence.



Samurai katana, 17th century

1281 The second Mongol invasion is repulsed after a typhoon wipes out the Mongol armada. This typhoon is called a *kamikaze*, or divine wind, sent by the gods to save Japan from the invaders.

1336 The Muromachi period, which lasts until 1573, begins. It is a period of devastating civil wars and the breakdown of central government, but also of growth in the arts and commerce.

1424 Zeami Kiyotsugu writes *Kakyo* (The Mirror of the Flower), in which he lays down the principles of Noh theater.

1467 The Onin War, triggered by a dispute over the accession within the Ashikaga shogunate, begins. It turns into a civil war that lasts for 100 years.

c.1542 The Portuguese land in Japan, probably the first Europeans to do so. They introduce the musket.

1592 The Japanese invade Korea and are defeated.

1597 A second Japanese invasion of Korea also ends in failure. Hideyoshi Toyotomi orders the execution by crucifixion of nine Catholic missionaries and 17 Japanese converts.

1600 In the Battle of Sekigahara, Tokugawa Ieyasu defeats Ishida Mitsunari to become master of Japan.

1603 Ieyasu is appointed

Shogun by the imperial court. He is now officially the man authorized to keep the peace in the emperor's name. The Tokugawa Shogunate will rule Japan for the next 265 years.

1635 Tokugawa Iemitsu, grandson of Ieyasu, issues an edict forbidding Japanese citizens to leave the country. Japan shuts itself off from the world.

1639 The Portuguese are excluded from Japan by Iemitsu, and Christianity is strictly prohibited. The period of *sakoku* (closed country) begins, with trade restricted to limited dealings with the Dutch and Chinese through Nagasaki.

1666 Samurai warrior Matsuo Basho becomes a *ronin* (a masterless samurai) when his lord dies. He renounces his warrior status to devote himself to poetry, perfecting the "new style" in the 17-syllable haiku form.

1830s Widespread famine leads to increasing popular unrest.

1836 An uprising in Gunnai district of Kai province (Yamanashi prefecture), attracts more than 50,000 participants and for a time reduces the center of Kai to anarchy. This is a direct challenge to the authority of the Tokugawa administration, the *bafuku*.

1841 Mizuno Tadakuni, the chief senior councillor, institutes the Tempo reforms aimed at rebuilding shattered communities after the famine, and also at curtailing samurai power.

1843 Tadakuni is forced from power. He predicts that, thanks to his reforms, the Tokugawa shogunate will survive for another 30 years. In fact it lasts just 25 more years.

1844–46 British and French warships visit the Ryukyu Islands and Nagasaki seeking to open up commercial relations with Japan.

1853 Commodore Matthew Perry of the US Navy enters Edo (Tokyo) harbor, and demands the opening of trade relations.

1854 A trade treaty is signed with the US, opening two ports to American shipping. Treaties with the UK, Russia, France, and others follow.

1859 The Shogun is assassinated by nationalists in a reaction against treaties with foreigners.

1863 Japanese fire on foreign vessels, leading to Anglo-Satsuma War.

1864 UK, US, French, and Dutch naval fleets force Japan to abide by the treaties.

1868 The Meiji Restoration results in the overthrow of the Tokugawa regime and the restoration of imperial power.

1871 The old feudal order is dismantled and all class privileges are removed, including the samurai class's monopoly of arms. A national army is formed.

1872 Modernization along western lines begins in earnest. Japan's strong military tradition becomes state-directed.

1877 The Satsuma clan revolt. Angry at the idea of a conscript army, they march on Kumamoto Castle and the whole army is sent in to crush them. Armed only with swords and a few Enfield rifles, the Satsuma are slaughtered—400 are left alive out of 20,000. The defeat marks the end of the samurai order.

1889 A constitution modeled on that of Bismarck's Germany is adopted, with a bicameral legislature and a constitutional monarchy. Only 1 percent of the population qualifies for office.

1894–95 War with China ends in Japanese victory. China is forced to withdraw from Korea, and cede the Liaotung Peninsula to Japan. Large-scale heavy industry is developed and foreign trade increases sharply.

1904–05 War with Russia ends in Japanese victory. Formosa (Taiwan) and Korea come under Japanese control.

1914 Japan joins World War I on the Allied side, seeing limited naval action.

1919 The Versailles peace conference gives Japan territorial gains in the Pacific.

1921 Prime Minister Hara Takashi is assassinated by a right-wing fanatic. Japan signs a naval arms limitation treaty

